GLOBAL MENTORSHIP INITIATIVE

Session 4 – Student Guide

Your Career Strategy



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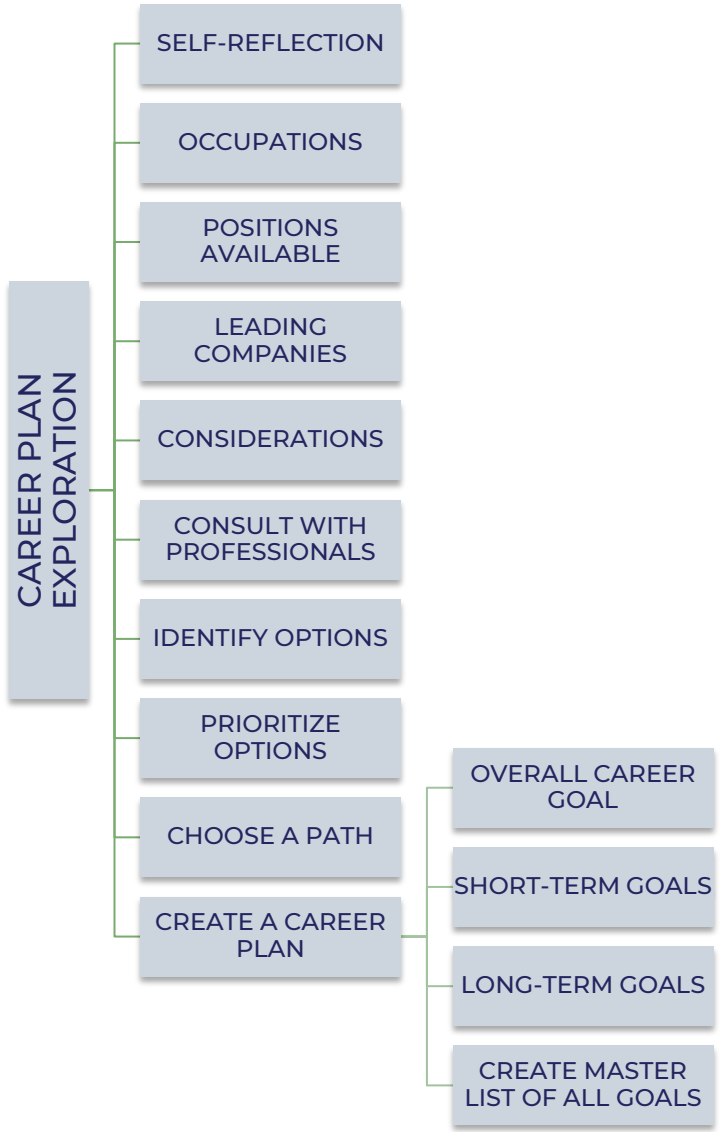
Before you Begin

What's a Career Plan?

- ✓ A career plan is a list of the short-term and long-term steps that need to be completed to reach an overall career goal.
- ✓ A career plan will look different for everyone depending on their profession, stage of life, resources, and the number of goals they have set.
- ✓ A career plan can be anything from an electronic document like this one, or a page in a notebook you keep with you.
- ✓ You should consistently evaluate your career plan and change it as you progress through your goals and learn more about your field.

Why Create a Career Plan?

- ✓ Career plans help provide purpose, control, and structure to your professional journey.
- ✓ Having a guide for your career goals will ultimately reduce the amount of stress caused by the uncertainty of what to do when working towards your goals.
- ✓ When you are unsure of what to do next, you will have a reference to see what you have completed and what else needs to be done to reach your goals.



"A goal without a plan is just a wish."
- Antoine de Saint-Exupéry

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How to Create a Career Plan

Overall Career Goals

- ✓ Now that you know the career path you are working towards, identify your overall career goal.
- ✓ An overall career goal should be a single sentence that sums up what you hope to do with your career.
- ✓ Your overall career goal does not need to be SMART. (Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, and Time-Bound), but your short-term goals and long-term goals should be.

Short-Term Goals

- ✓ Short-term goals are smaller, first steps that can be completed in one year or less and need to occur before you can reach your overall career goal.
- ✓ A helpful first step to take is to ask yourself where you want to be in one year. Think about what you want to accomplish in the next year and use it to help guide what you need to accomplish.
- ✓ Another helpful way to create short-term goals is to evaluate your qualifications for the career goal you have set for yourself.
- ✓ Refer to the skills, education, and other barriers you identified on the 'Career Exploration Worksheet' in Track 2. Are there skills you need to develop to be a qualified professional in your field? Do you need to complete additional education, training, or certifications?
- ✓ Additionally, on the 'Career Exploration Worksheet' you listed professionals you could have an informational interview with or job shadow, and internship or apprenticeship.
- ✓ Informational interviews, job shadows, internships and apprenticeships are all short-term goals to help expand your knowledge on your field and grow your skills.



Longer-Term Goals

- ✓ Long-term goals are steps to your overall career goals that will take more than one year to accomplish.
- ✓ Think about where you want to be in 3 years and 5 years.
- ✓ Some of the skills, education, certifications, trainings, and other barriers identified for your short-term goals may require more time to accomplish and become your long-term goals

Master List

- ✓ For a career plan to be the most effective at helping you achieve your professional goals, it must be written down somewhere you can refer to it often and change it when need be.
- ✓ Save your career plan as a document or write it down in a notebook and review it often to be reminded of your goals and progress.
- ✓ The career planning process is never-ending, you should constantly be working and re-working your career plan to fit your needs and goals.

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Tips for Setting Career Goals

1. Achieving your goals requires perseverance but always remember your motivation.
2. Remember, money alone is not enough to keep you motivated.
3. Create visual reminders of your motivation to display in your home and where you work.
4. Create a timeline for your career goals.
5. Be patient. Achieving your goals takes time.
6. Track your progress and accomplishments and reward yourself for your success.
7. Share your goals with family, friends, and coworkers to keep yourself accountable.
8. Don't hesitate to ask for help, even if you think you can do it alone.
9. Surround yourself with people who are just as motivated as you are.
10. Visualize yourself achieving the career goals you have set for yourself.

AI Questions/Queries for Career Goals

Informational Interviews

- ✓ Write an email to Jim Smith, a Financial Analyst asking for an informational interview to learn more about the work he does at <company>.
- ✓ What questions should I ask someone to learn more about what they do as a software engineer at <company>?
- ✓ Write a thank-you note to Jim Smith who gave me an informational interview about being a software engineer at <company>. Ask them if they could refer me for potential job opportunities.

Industry Associations

- ✓ What professional associations in <country> should I join for software engineers?

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Find the Right Career Path for You

1 - Self-Reflection

- ✓ Self-reflection is the process of reflecting on your motivation, interests, values, and skills and using them to explore your career path options.
- ✓ Use 'Worksheet – Career Path Exploration' to document your plan for each section below.

2 - Occupations in Your Field

- ✓ Research the different occupations available with your degree.
- ✓ Your college professors and college counselors are a great resource for information on career routes within your program. Reach out to them with any questions during your research.
- ✓ Have you taken any college courses that cover the different occupations in this field?
- ✓ Are there occupations that stand out to you?
- ✓ Do you already know which occupation under your degree you are interested in pursuing?

Additional Resources on Occupations

'Types of Careers by Industry, Job, and Salary' – The Balance Careers
https://www.thebalancecareers.com/different-types-of-jobs-a-z-list-2059643



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Find the Right Career Path for You

3 - Positions Available

- ✓ Now that you know the occupations available, research the positions available under each occupation you are interested in.
- ✓ Helpful websites include LinkedIn, Indeed, Monster, ZipRecruiter, and Career Builder.

4 – Leading Companies

- ✓ Learn who the leading companies are within your field and for the specific occupations.
- ✓ Your mentor is a great resource for this information.
  - ✓ What company does your mentor work with?
  - ✓ Who are their competitors?
- ✓ Which companies are innovators in the field?
- ✓ You can also look at the websites listed above to see which companies have job listings in your field.

5 - Considerations

Skills Required

- ✓ Make a list of the specific skills needed in your profession and the positions you listed in step 2 and 3.
- ✓ This information can be found in the 'Job Requirements' section of job descriptions. Browse through the job descriptions for the positions you identified in step 3 and list the common skills required.
- ✓ What skills do you have that are beneficial in your field?
- ✓ What skills are required for your field that you do not have?



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Find the Right Career Path for You

5 – Considerations - continued

Salaries

- ✓ Research the salary ranges for the positions you identified in step 3.
- ✓ Consider how important salary is to you when exploring your career path options.
- ✓ Do you have some flexibility with salary?
- ✓ Who will your salary support?
- ✓ Glassdoor is a helpful website for finding information on salaries and health benefits reported by colleagues in the field and how the numbers and benefits differ between companies. https://www.glassdoor.com/index.htm

Education

- ✓ Research the minimum education required for positions for the occupations you are interested in.
- ✓ This information can be found in the 'Qualifications' section of job descriptions. Look through the entry-level positions as well as the higher-level positions that you eventually would like to work in.
- ✓ Consider what level of education is required. If there are additional certifications, trainings, or even graduate programs required will you be able to obtain them?

Other Factors

- ✓ Consider other barriers to your career goals.
- ✓ For instance, investigate which positions are hiring or are in high demand.
- ✓ What other factors might interfere with your ability to pursue an occupation within your degree?
- ✓ Ask your mentor what barriers prevented them from pursuing different career paths.



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Find the Right Career Path for You

6 - Consult with Professionals

Informational Interviews

- ✓ Reach out to professionals in the field and request to meet with them for 30 minutes in person or over the phone to discuss their career path and ask a few questions about the industry.
- ✓ Try to find people who are working in occupations that you would like to learn more about. Ask them questions about where they started and how they got to the position they are in now.

Job Shadowing

- ✓ Many people are happy to have students shadow them to learn more about the work they do.
- ✓ Job shadowing is a valuable way to learn how professionals in your field work on a daily basis.
- ✓ Additionally, job shadowing is an affordable way to quickly learn if a specific occupation or position is right for you and can help you narrow down your career path choices.
- ✓ Shadowing professionals is also an advantageous way to make professional connections that could lead to a job.
- ✓ Use your personal and business relationships to connect with professionals who are working in occupations you are interested in learning more about.



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Find the Right Career Path for You

6 - Consult with Professionals - continued

Internships

- ✓ An internship is a temporary position with a company, either part-time or full-time, working as an entry-level professional in your field.
- ✓ Internships are a great way to learn how a company works and the daily tasks required for the different positions.
- ✓ Many companies welcome interns, as they are an inexpensive way to get work done.
- ✓ To inquire about internships with a specific company, go to their website and look at the career section.
- ✓ If there is a company you would like to intern for, but they do not have a posting for an internship position on their website, then send an email or call the company letting them know you are interested in an internship opportunity.
- ✓ Leverage your personal connections and professional network. Who do you know who works at a company you are interested in?
- ✓ Websites to search for internships: Internships.com, Indeed.com, Idealist.org, and GoAbroad.com.

Apprenticeships

- ✓ Apprenticeships are a great way to earn an income while you learn more about the field.
- ✓ An apprenticeship is where you work as an apprentice, or a trainee, under a skilled professional who provides a combination of training and job shadowing while you still receive a paycheck.
- ✓ Apprenticeships are harder to come by than internships, are longer, and are not always available.
- ✓ Do you know anyone who has done an apprenticeship before? Ask them to discuss their experience with you.



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Find the Right Career Path for You

7 – Identify Options

- ✓ With the information about your field, use this to identify your possible career path options.
- ✓ List all the occupations and/or positions that you have the skills and education to do, or that you can get the required additional training and education for.
- ✓ In this step, consider the skills, salaries, education, and other factors identified in step 5.
- ✓ What occupations are you unable to do because of education or financial reasons?

8 – Prioritize Options

- ✓ Compare your motivations, interests, and values to the occupations and positions in your current list from step 7 and narrow down the list to the possible occupations and positions that match your motivation, interests, and values.
- ✓ What occupations and positions motivate you?
- ✓ Which of the occupations or positions include your personal and professional interests?

9 – Choose a Path

- ✓ Now that you have narrowed down the list of possible occupations and positions to only include the occupations you are able to do and that you would want to do, pick your first choice and two backup plans.
- ✓ It is a smart idea to have at least two back up career path choices in case the first choice does not work for unforeseen reasons.

10 – Create a Career Plan

- ✓ Now that you have narrowed down your career path choice, it is time to create your career plan!



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Further Discussion

Questions to Ask Your Mentor

- ✓ How did you decide between multiple career paths when you were starting your career?
- ✓ Do you feel you made the right decision for your career path? Why or why not?
- ✓ What if I make the wrong decision for my career path?
- ✓ Did you have a written career plan after college? If so, were you able to follow your career plan? What worked well? What didn't?
- ✓ Do you still have a career plan? If so, how do you stay focused to meet your goals?

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Action Items Before Next Session

Before Session 5

- ✓ Complete the “Professional Skills” and “SMART Goals” worksheets prior to your next session
- ✓ Mark Session 4 as complete on the Student Portal

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References

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- ‘8 Steps to an Effective Career Plan’ – Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT) https://capd.mit.edu/resources/make-a-career-plan/

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References for Achieving Your Goals

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- ’10 Ways to Stay Motivated When Negativity Seems to be All Around’ – Stacia Peirce with The Huffington Post https://www.huffingtonpost.com/stacia-pierce/10-ways-to-stay-motivated_b_4941277.html

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- ‘4 Steps to Help You Choose the Right Career’ – The Ladders https://www.theladders.com/career-advice/4-steps-to-help-you-choose-the-right-career

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- ‘Make a Career Plan: 8 Steps to an Effective Career Plan’ – Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT) https://capd.mit.edu/resources/make-a-career-plan/

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